

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

FROM SUSHASAN TO SURAAJ

After ensuring victories for chief ministers such as Arvind Kejriwal, Mamata Banerjee and M.K. Stalin in the past two years, poll strategist **Prashant Kishor** seems to have returned to his pandemic-interrupted personal mission. In February 2020, Kishor, who hails from Bihar, had launched the '*Baat Bihar Ki*' programme to connect with the 10 million youth who wish "to see the state among the top 10 in India". The political ambition was evident as he unleashed a scathing attack on Nitish Kumar for his failure to develop Bihar despite three terms as CM. On May 2, Kishor announced that he was going back to the people in his quest for *jan suraaj* (good governance for the people) and that the journey would begin from Bihar. The Nitish imprint is still there, though. While the CM is popularly known as *sushasan babu* (good governance man), Kishor wants to herald *suraaj* in Bihar.

Jr's Ministerial Debut?



Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin completed a year in office on May 7, and now his son **Udayanidhi Stalin**, a first-time MLA and the ruling DMK's youth wing secretary, seems set to join his father's cabinet. The 44-year-old actor-producer is tipped to get charge of municipal administration and youth affairs. The DMK youth wing, which has had representation in every party-led ministry since 1989, will also get a member onboard with this.

WHO'S THAT PATIENT

Uttar Pradesh deputy CM **Brijesh Pathak**, who holds the health and medical education department portfolios, inspected more than a dozen government hospitals disguised as a patient in the past one month. Disappointed with the health services at 10 of them, he has served showcause notices to the superintendents of these hospitals. With the surprise inspections in the news, government hospitals in UP are now on high alert. Authorities are always on the lookout for a six-foot-tall masked patient. It may be Pathak on the prowl.



–Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Amarnath K. Menon, Amitabh Srivastava and Romita Datta



COW-SAVVY CANDIDATE

Amit Shah acolyte and Union MoS for home **Nityanand Rai** is already seen as someone in line for a leadership role in Bihar. The BJP leader set social media agog on May 1 after party spokesman Nikhil Anand posted pictures of Rai with a cow on a media WhatsApp group. Being seen with a cow is important as Rai, a Yadav (traditional cowherds, they are numerically the single largest caste in Bihar), is being projected as an alternative to RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav.



Shawl Diplomacy

Mamata Banerjee was attending the joint conference of state chief justices and chief ministers in the national capital when she had a brief meeting with **Prime Minister Narendra Modi** and CJI N.V. Ramana over tea. The West Bengal CM had come armed with silk Kantha shawls in mustard yellow and green and she chose the latter—green with flowers imprinted—for the PM. No prizes for guessing her intent, but the TMC symbol is twin flowers with grass.